HACK 876 × Hillel

Hillel calls it learning for living. Hack 876 is one day of exactly that.

Hack 876 is a one-day build competition bringing about 80 Jamaican secondary-school students together to turn ideas into working prototypes.



KINGSTON • FEB 20, 2027 (TENTATIVE) • ~80 BUILDERS • TEAMS OF 3–4

Learning for living, in a single day.

Hillel's mission is to inspire problem-solving, lifelong learners. Hack 876 asks students to do precisely that: find a real problem and build an answer to it, together, in one day.

Hack 876 adds something a school timetable cannot easily provide: students from other schools, a fixed deadline, mentors from industry, and judges who ask students to explain their decisions. It is an addition to what Hillel already does, not a replacement for any of it.



Learning for Living
Hillel Academy's motto.

Real-world learning
The High School describes its approach as connecting learning "through real-world application".

IB World School
Hillel offers the IB Diploma, with Creativity, Activity and Service as part of the programme.

Beyond the classroom
Every High School student is expected to take part in at least two co-curricular activities each term.

Robotics
The Hillel Panthers were selected to represent Jamaica at the FIRST World Championship in Houston in April 2025.

> **"To inspire well-rounded, problem-solving, lifelong learners and confident global citizens prepared to change the world."**
>
> Hillel Academy mission statement · hillelacademyjm.com

02 THE HILLEL CONNECTION

Built by people Hillel helped shape.

One of Hack 876's organizers and one of its confirmed judges attended Hillel. They are helping build this because they would have wanted it as students.



CONFIRMED ORGANIZER

Stefen Ewers

Hillel → Campion College → Georgia Tech

Now: Georgia Tech



CONFIRMED JUDGE

Kendall Todd

Hillel → UF

Now: Accenture

Employers are listed as each person's affiliation. They are not event sponsors unless stated elsewhere.

One day. Build something real.

~80 TOTAL BUILDERS

3–4 PER TEAM

1 DAY

A hackathon is an event where small teams build something from scratch in a single day, then present it to judges. No programming experience is needed: teams also need students who design, research, write and present. Mentors who work in industry help throughout the day.

STEP 1

Think

Find a real problem worth solving.

STEP 2

Build

Turn the idea into a working prototype.

STEP 3

Ship

Get it running before the clock stops.

STEP 4

Present

Demo it to judges and explain the decisions.

Websites · Apps · AI tools · Games · Hardware · Data projects · Automations · Agents · Interactive experiences

Not an AI-only hackathon. Teams build whatever the problem needs.

04 WHAT STUDENTS GAIN

More than a project.

It won't decide anyone's career. It gives students a useful early signal about whether building technology excites them.

Teamwork
Working with people who think differently.

Scoping
Learning what can really be built in a day.

Technical problem solving
Turning a concept into something that works.

Decision making
Choosing between ideas under real constraints.

Communication
Explaining what they built to judges and peers.

Resilience
Shipping something even when it isn't perfect.

Exposure
Meeting students and professionals beyond their usual circle.

Confidence
Moving from using technology to making it.

05 BEFORE UNIVERSITY

Before the internship. Before university. Before the first job.

Give them the first build.

University programs increasingly expect collaboration, coding, product thinking, research and fast prototyping. Most students meet all of that at once for the first time in their first year.

Hack 876 gives them an early taste of:

- University hackathons
- Product building
- Pitching an idea
- Portfolio work
- Engineering teamwork
- Software development
- Talking through a project in an interview
- Working across disciplines

06 PARTICIPATION

Hillel in the room.

Hack 876 is for students in 5th Form through Upper 6th Form. Participating schools recommend students, and recommended students apply. No place is assumed until applications and selection happen.

8–12

PLANNING RANGE · NOT GUARANTEED

For early planning, a cohort of roughly 8–12 Hillel students fits the scale we're considering. With about 80 places across participating schools, final representation depends on applications and overall capacity.

Teams of 3–4. Students can apply solo or with friends, and teams may mix schools. Final team-formation rules are still being finalized.

WHAT WE'D LIKE FROM HILLEL

1. Support in principle for eligible Hillel students, in Grades 11 to 13, to take part.
2. Guidance from Hillel's leadership on any administrative requirements.
3. A faculty liaison of the school's choosing, possibly within Technology Education.
4. Guidance in identifying one or two student ambassadors.
5. Help reaching curious, motivated students, and recommending those who are interested.
6. Guidance on permissions, communication with parents and any school-specific expectations.

We're not asking Hillel for financial support, or to organize anything. Hack 876 runs the event, the applications, the judging and the participant materials. What form of support is appropriate is for the school to decide.

07 COMPETITION

Build it. Present it. Compete for it.

Prizes across overall placement and special categories. The exact package will keep developing as sponsors are finalized, and participating schools will get updates.

OVERALL PLACEMENT

Hack 876 Winner
The whole thing. Best overall build.
iPad per student (up to 4)

Second Place
So close. Still brilliant.
AirPods Pro per student (up to 4)

Third Place
On the podium.
US$150 gift card per student (up to 4)

SPECIAL AWARDS

Best Design
Looks great. Feels even better.
US$50 gift card per student (up to 4)

Boldest Idea
The swing nobody else took.
US$200 team project grant

People's Choice
Voted by the room.
US$50 gift card per student (up to 4)

Categories are set. Prize items are tentative and may change. Prizes are a bonus, not the reason to come.

08 WORKING WITH HILLEL

A conversation first.

We would like Hack 876 to become something Hillel students can return to each year, not a single Saturday. That work is under way with the school's leadership and its Technology Education team.

PREPARED FOR

Mr. Lloyd Holmes

High School Principal · Hillel Academy

At Hillel since 2004 · High School Principal since 2017

We are coordinating with Mr. Holmes and Hillel's Technology Education team on what school participation would involve and what approval Hillel requires.

Ms. Delrose Coburn POTENTIAL FACULTY LIAISON

Head of Technology Education. Ms. Coburn has been part of our early conversations. Who acts as faculty liaison, if anyone, is for Hillel to decide.

Student ambassadors PROPOSED

One or two students, chosen with the school, who help classmates understand the opportunity and bring their questions back.



The Hack 876 organizing team runs event operations, applications and all official communication with students and parents.

Hillel Academy has not yet confirmed its participation, nobody at Hillel has accepted a role, and student places are not guaranteed.

09 WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

We'll fill in the details together.

Hillel doesn't need every answer today to join the conversation.

NOW
Coordination with Mr. Holmes and the Technology Education team on participation arrangements.

IF HILLEL AGREES
Support in principle, and any approval steps the school requires.

THEN
A faculty liaison and one or two student ambassadors.

BEFORE THE EVENT
Teachers recommend students, students apply, and families receive consent forms.

EVENT DAY
Hack 876.

DECIDED

- One-day build competition
- Venue: Spanish Court Hotel, Kingston
- 5th Form through Upper 6th Form
- About 80 places
- Schools recommend, students apply
- Applications are open

PLANNED

- Tentative date: Saturday, February 20, 2027
- A 8:00 AM to 7:30 PM day
- Lunch on the day
- Overall and special prize categories
- Industry judges and mentors

BEING FINALIZED

- Confirming the date
- School-level allocations and team rules
- Cost and transport
- Prize items
- Family details: supervision, food, emergency contacts

Participating schools and applicants will receive detailed information as each part of the event is finalized.

LEARNING FOR LIVING · HILLEL ACADEMY'S MOTTO.

Hillel teaches learning for living. Let's give a few Hillel students one day to live it.

HACK 876 · KINGSTON, JAMAICA · FEB 20, 2027 (TENTATIVE)

info@hack876.com

ABOUT HILLEL: SOURCES

1. Hillel Academy: Mission and Values
2. Hillel Academy: The Principal, High School
3. Hillel Academy: About Us
4. Hillel Academy: High School co-curricular programme
5. Jamaica Observer: 2024-25 FIRST Tech Challenge Jamaica Robotics Championship (April 16, 2025)

Prepared by Hack 876 for the Hillel community. This is not an official Hillel Academy publication, and Hillel's participation has not been confirmed. Dates, allocations and prizes are provisional.